Who Holds the Lever

A Short Guide to the Oldest Mechanism of Power—and How to See It

Macharia Barii

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There is a mechanism of power so old and so common that we rarely notice it. It has no name in everyday speech, which is part of why it works.

Here is the mechanism in one sentence: *whoever controls access to something you want can shape what you do—without force, without threats, without even asking.*

A boss controls your paycheck. A platform controls your audience. A landlord controls your home. A church controls a ritual you believe in. A government controls a permit you need. In each case, someone holds something you want, and makes access to it conditional on how you behave.

I call this a *lever*. Not because it is exotic, but because it is simple—and because once you see it, you see it everywhere.

The first thing to notice: the terms are not yours

When someone holds a lever over you, the question is never just "what do they want?" It is "what counts as good behavior in their eyes?"

And that is the first surprise. The standard is set by the person holding the lever, not by you. What counts as a good employee, a good citizen, a good believer, a good partner—these are not natural facts. They are definitions, and the person with the lever is the one who writes them.

This matters more than it sounds. It means the lever does not simply reward you for doing things. It rewards you for *being* what the lever-holder wants you to be—and that can include your attitude, your tone, your associations, your silences, even your feelings. A boss who wants loyalty, a church that wants faith, a platform that wants engagement—each is asking for something more than behavior. Each is asking for alignment.

And alignment is judged by them.

The second thing: your real power is your alternatives

Here is the part that is genuinely liberating, and it is the heart of everything that follows.

The lever-holder's power over you is limited by what you can do instead.

If you have one employer in a company town, that employer can demand almost anything. If you have five offers in a city, the same employer must bargain. If you can leave the church and still have a community, the church must persuade. If you cannot leave, it need not.

Nothing about the lever-holder changed. What changed was your alternatives.

This is why the most important question in any relationship of power is not "how strong are they?" It is "how easily can I walk away?" Everything else—how much they demand, how they treat you, whether they bother to explain themselves—follows from that.

The people with the most freedom are not the strongest people. They are the people with somewhere else to go.

A note on what freedom means here

There are two kinds of freedom, and this essay is about both.

The first is *space*—the freedom of alternatives. Can you leave? Do you have somewhere else to go? Space is the freedom that can be given, built, bought, inherited, or lost. It has a price, because alternatives cost something to make and to keep. This is why space is the freedom that politics and economics are mostly about, and why a person with resources can acquire more of it than a person without.

The second is *time*—the freedom of the pause between what happens to you and what you do about it. Can you wait before responding? Can you ask why you want what you want before you go get it? Time is not priced. There is no market for the pause. No one can sell it to you, and no one can take it from you without your cooperation. It is the one form of freedom that does not respond to resources, which is why it is available to the rich and the poor alike.

This is why the practical advice splits in two. If you have resources, buy space—build alternatives, keep exits open, do not let yourself be priced. If you do not, cultivate time—keep the pause, ask the fifth question, do not react on schedule, keep a small reserve of yourself that no one else can read. The first is the strategy of the person with something to spend. The second is the strategy of everyone, and it is the one that cannot be taken from you.

Space can be given, built, or bought. Time has to be kept. The lever-holder can read your preferences. He cannot read the moment you will decide. Keep that moment open. It is the smallest unit of freedom there is, and it is the one no one can take from you without your help.

A further note on the asymmetry between them

Space is priced, and because it is priced, it can be bought. And because it can be bought, it generates returns—the person who buys alternatives can use them to acquire more. This is one reason the rich get richer, and it is not a malfunction of the system. It is the structure of space. Alternatives are an asset, and assets compound.

Time is not priced, and because it is not priced, it cannot be bought, and it cannot be converted into space. A person rich in time cannot trade it for alternatives; the market does not accept that currency. So the person who cannot buy space has only time—and the time cannot be spent on the things that space would buy.

This is the quiet structure of a great deal of inequality, and it is not a story about virtue or effort. It is a story about which freedom responds to resources and which one does not. The rich buy space, and the buying compounds. The poor keep time, and the keeping is all that remains.

But here is the thing that keeps this from being a counsel of despair. Time is the freedom that no one can take from you without your help. The rich can buy space. They cannot buy the pause. The poor cannot buy space. They can keep the pause—and the pause is where every refusal begins, every question, every small unpredictable choice that a lever-holder cannot price.

The asymmetry is real. It is not the whole story. The one freedom that cannot be bought is also the one that cannot be taken. That is not consolation. It is strategy.

Work is a lever too

It is easy to read everything in this essay as a warning about other people's power over you. But when you take a job, you are not only the agent. You are a principal too. You control access to something your employer wants—your attention, your skill, your judgment, your time—and you make access conditional on a wage. The employment relationship is not a lever and its absence. It is two levers facing each other, and the terms are set where they meet.

So what are you actually trading?

You are selling *time*—the hours in which you might have done something else. And you are selling *alignment*—a state of yourself that the employer values: your knowledge, your judgment, your reliability, your willingness.

What you receive is resources. And resources are best understood as claims on space. Money is the most general claim: it can be turned into almost any alternative. But wages have been paid in many things—grain, ore, land, plunder, company scrip, shares—and each of these is a claim on space in a particular form. A farmhand paid in grain is paid in the output of land. A worker paid in company scrip is paid in a claim that can only be spent at the company store. The form of the wage is not neutral. It tells you what kind of freedom the employer expects you to accumulate.

Which brings us to the thing that takes time. An occupation is a trade of time for space. You sell the pause, and you receive claims on alternatives. The question every worker should ask is not only "what does it pay?" but "what does it let me leave?" A job that pays well and gives you no alternatives is not a good job. It is a well-paid cage. A job that pays less and gives you savings, transferable skills, and a reputation you can carry elsewhere may be worth more than the wage suggests—because the wage is spent, and the space is kept.

And there is a trap hidden in the word "benefit." Some of what you receive is not space at all. It is a claim on space that is conditional on your continued alignment. Vesting schedules, employer-specific training, stock that matures only if you stay, pensions that pay only if you retire from the firm, credentials recognized only in this industry, a reputation worth something only in this city—these are not gifts. They are tethers. They look like generosity, and the generosity is real, but the condition is the point. You have not been given space. You have been given a promise of space, and the promise is void if you leave.

So when you are offered a benefit, ask not what it is worth, but what it is conditional on. A benefit conditional on your staying is not a benefit. It is a longer leash. A benefit you can carry with you is space. The two look similar at the moment of the offer. They are opposites in the long run.

And the last thing about work, which is the thing most workers never notice: the business owner and the worker are in the same boat. They are both trading time for space, both trying to accumulate claims on alternatives, both subject to the same asymmetry between the two freedoms. The difference is not the kind of boat. It is the resources they start with, and the rate at which their claims compound. The owner begins with more space, and space compounds faster than wages do. The worker begins with less, and the wage buys less space each year. They are not in different games. They are in the same game, with different starting positions

and different rates of accumulation. That is the structure, and it is worth seeing clearly—not to stir resentment, but because a person who understands the game they are in plays it better than one who does not.

Governance is the lever at scale

Everything in this essay applies to a boss, a platform, a church. It also applies to a state—but a state is a lever with three features no other lever-holder has.

First, the state claims a monopoly on force. Most levers in this essay are voluntary: the agent can leave, and the lever-holder must restrain because the agent's exit would cost them. The state is the principal that can remove exit. It can jail you, fine you, conscript you, and in the extreme case kill you. This is why the convergence between ethics and durability—the reason decent arrangements tend to outlast exploitative ones—holds only within the domain where force is unavailable. The state is the principal that steps outside that domain. A state that can jail its citizens does not need their consent, and the arithmetic that restrains the ordinary lever-holder does not restrain it in the same way.

That is not a counsel of despair. It is a reason to be clear-eyed. The rest of this section is about what actually constrains a state, and it turns out to be the same thing that constrains every other lever-holder: alternatives, and the network of other levers around it.

Second, most of what a state does, most of the time, is voluntary. It does not jail most people. It issues permits and licenses, collects taxes, distributes benefits, employs public servants, approves regulations, certifies identity, recognizes contracts, and provides infrastructure. Each of these is a lever. The citizen wants the permit, the benefit, the recognition, the road; the state makes access conditional on compliance. For most citizens most of the time, the state is not a coercer but a lever-holder—and the five questions work on a government as well as on a boss.

Third, the state is the principal the agent cannot easily punish. A worker who leaves a bad employer imposes a cost. A citizen who leaves a bad state usually cannot, and even when they can, the state survives their departure. The citizen's exit threat is weak against a state. So what constrains it? The answer is the network. A state surrounded by other levers it does not control—a free press, independent courts, competitive elections, a plural civil society, federalism, international institutions—is a state whose own alternatives are multiplied. The citizen cannot personally leave the state. But the state can be constrained by the network of principals around it. This is why "many people to deal with" is a form of protection.

And this is the danger. The state is the only principal that can close the network. It can license competitors out of existence, regulate the press into silence, capture the courts, absorb the organizations that would otherwise check it, and control the formation environment through schools, media, and national narrative. When a state does all of these things, the network collapses into a single effective principal, and the extraction limit returns to the bilateral level. The word for this is not "governance." It is "capture."

So the questions for a state are parallel to the questions for a job. Is the state surrounded? Not "is it democratic"—the formal institutions can exist while the network has collapsed. Is it actually constrained by other levers it does not control? A free press that can be shut down is not a constraint. A court that can be packed is not a constraint. The question is whether the alternatives to the state's goods are real.

Is the state forming you? Every state shapes. The question is whether the shaping is in the

light or in the dark, whether there are alternative formation environments the state does not control, and whether you can ask the fifth question about your own political preferences without being unable to answer. A state that has captured the formation environment has captured the citizen's time as well as their space—and the citizen may not notice, because the preferences arrived already decided.

A state that is surrounded and does not form you is a state that has to earn your compliance. A state that is not surrounded, and does form you, is not a government. It is a lever-holder wearing the name of one. The difference is not a matter of ideology. It is the same difference the rest of this essay has been describing, at a larger scale—and it is worth seeing clearly, because it is the difference between a citizenry and an audience.

The third thing: they cannot use what they do not know

There is a catch for the lever-holder, and it is a big one.

To set the terms well, they have to know what you actually want. Too high a price and you refuse, or leave, or pretend to agree while quietly doing something else. Too low and they leave value on the table.

So the lever creates a demand for knowledge—and a demand for knowledge creates a whole apparatus to get it.

This is what confession is. What performance reviews are. What customer surveys, credit scores, background checks, recommendation algorithms and intelligence services are. They are all answers to the same question: what does this person actually want, and how much would they give for it?

And here is the corresponding truth for you: *your privacy is not a luxury. It is your leverage.*

If they cannot read you, they cannot price you. If they cannot price you, they must offer better terms. An unreadable person is a harder person to manage. This is why secrecy, discretion, and the simple habit of not telling everyone everything are not paranoia. They are strategy.

It is also why the answer is not "maximum secrecy." Total opacity has costs—you become untrustworthy, unemployable, alone. The right amount is the amount that keeps you from being fully predictable, without making you impossible to deal with. Opacity is a tool, not a religion.

And the practical form of this is smaller than it sounds. Being a bit unpredictable is a big deal. You do not need to be mysterious. You need to be slightly harder to price than the person who answers every question immediately, explains every decision, and does exactly what is expected. A small reserve—a habit of not replying at once, of not narrating every choice, of keeping some preferences private, of occasionally doing the unexpected thing—is enough to shift the terms. Not because it is dramatic, but because a person who can be fully read can be fully governed, and a person who cannot is a little bit freer than they were.

There is a second way to keep from being read, and it is more powerful than privacy. Instead of revealing nothing, you can reveal something false. You can let their apparatus do its work on a picture of you that you have arranged. The better their instruments, the more damage the false picture does—because the confidence of a reader who has read you well is the confidence of someone who will not check again.

This works. It is ancient. It is also a different instrument from privacy, and it carries a different cost.

Privacy is the refusal to be known. Deception is the manufacture of a false belief. The first says nothing and leaves them with less. The second says something untrue and leaves them with wrong. The first is a reserve. The second is a trick.

This essay takes the position that the first is part of the agent's legitimate counter-power and the second is not—not because deception never works, but because a world in which everyone manufactures false beliefs is a world in which no one can be trusted, and the person who suffers most from that is the person with the least power to verify. The strong can afford to be deceived once. The weak cannot afford to be deceived at all, and cannot afford to be the deceiver either, because the reputation for deceit falls hardest on those who have no other reputation to fall back on.

So: keep something to yourself. That is reserve, and it is yours. Be careful about what you put in its place.

The fourth thing: promises about the future need proof

Some levers pay out immediately. Do this, get that, today.

But the most powerful levers pay out later—and later is harder to trust. Heaven, promotion, pension, legacy, the long-term payoff of loyalty. The problem is that you cannot check whether the promise is real until it is too late.

So the lever-holder must invest in credibility. They build institutions, write texts, create rituals, train professionals, publish rules, submit to audits. All of this is machinery for making a future promise believable today.

Which means: when someone is selling you a future, ask what they have spent to make it believable. The answer tells you how seriously to take the offer.

The fifth thing—and this is the deepest one

Everything so far assumes you already know what you want.

But what if you don't? Or worse—what if what you want was put there?

A person who can shape what you desire does not need to bargain with you at all. They set the terms of the game before you sit down to play. They don't have to convince you to want the promotion, the product, the salvation, the body, the life. They make you want it, and then they sell it to you—and the exchange feels like your own choice, because as far as you can tell, it is.

This is the difference between being outmatched and being formed. The first you can notice. The second you usually cannot.

And it is everywhere. Education shapes what you find interesting. Advertising shapes what you find desirable. Media shapes what you find important. Communities shape what you find shameful. None of this is a conspiracy; most of it is done by people who believe they are helping. But the effect is the same. The most powerful lever is the one that makes you want what the lever-holder has to offer—and leaves you convinced the wanting was always yours.

There is a name for the condition in which this has gone all the way: *capture*. It is when you have no alternatives, and then you stop needing them, because you have absorbed their standard as your own. You don't feel controlled. You feel like yourself. That is precisely what makes it complete.

And this is the one lever that attacks both freedoms at once.

Think about what formation does. Your space is your alternatives. Your time is your pause. A principal who plants desires does not have to close your exits—he makes the exits lead back to him. And he does not have to take your time—he fills the pause before you notice it was there.

Your alternatives now point toward his goods, because those are the goods you want. And the pause, where you would ask *why do I want this?*, gets filled with an answer you did not choose—or it never opens at all, because the wanting arrived already decided.

This is why the fifth question is the hardest one, and the most important. *Are these wants yours?* It is the only question that works against a formation attack. And it can only be asked in the pause. Which means the formation principal is not primarily attacking your alternatives. He is attacking the pause itself—the moment in which you would notice that you need alternatives at all.

Keep the pause open. It is the front line.

So why doesn't the lever-holder simply take everything?

Because they usually can't—and this is the most hopeful part of the whole story.

The person holding the lever wants two things: to extract as much as possible, and to keep the lever in place. These two goals pull against each other.

Push too hard, and people leave. Or worse, they stop believing the promise was real, and the whole structure collapses. Every empire that overreached, every church that sold too openly, every company that squeezed its workers and customers at once—they all discovered the same thing. Extraction is easy. Durability is hard.

So the clever lever-holder restrains. Not out of kindness—out of arithmetic. They keep the terms tolerable because tolerable terms are what keep you in the game.

This is the quiet reason why ethical arrangements tend to outlast exploitative ones. It is not that virtue always wins. It is that the arrangement which respects your ability to leave is the arrangement that survives your ability to leave. Where force is available, this logic breaks down—a state that can jail you does not need your consent. But wherever the lever must be voluntary, the same conclusion keeps returning:

The conditions that make a relationship decent are the conditions that make it last.

Why "many people to deal with" is a form of protection

One more thing, because it explains a lot of the world.

When many people hold levers, and none of them dominates, you are safer. You can play them against each other. Your alternatives multiply. This is why competition protects consumers, why federalism protects citizens, why a free press protects the public, why a diversified set of relationships protects a person.

The danger comes when the many collapse into one—when the competitors merge, the agencies coordinate, the platforms consolidate, the interests align. That is when a network becomes captured, and when the many parties you thought you were dealing with turn out to be one.

Corruption, lobbying, and coercion look like different things. They are the same thing: the lever, operating among many players, before or after the moment when the many become one. The difference between a market and a cartel is not the number of participants. It is whether you can still walk away.

What to do with this

This is not a self-help program. It is a set of questions you can ask about any arrangement you are in—a job, a relationship, a platform, a church, a country.

Five of them.

Is it transparent? Do you know what is being asked of you, and what you get in return? Or is the deal deliberately fuzzy?

Can you leave? Not in theory—in practice. Could you actually go, without ruin? If not, you are not negotiating. You are complying.

Can you argue? Can you dispute the terms, or is the standard beyond question? An arrangement you can criticize is an arrangement that has to earn your loyalty.

Can you keep something to yourself? Or is every preference, every habit, every hesitation being read, measured, and priced?

And the hardest one: **are these wants yours?** Did you choose this goal, or did someone choose it for you and arrange for you to feel as though you had chosen it? If you cannot tell, that is itself the answer—and it is worth finding people and places that help you tell.

Five questions. They work on almost anything.

The last thing

Knowledge like this cuts both ways.

Told to the person holding the lever, it is a manual for extraction: here is how to find what they want, here is how to make the terms stick, here is how to keep them from noticing.

Told to the person under the lever, it is something else entirely. It is a language for naming what is happening, and a map of where the exits are.

There is no neutral version. Anyone who claims to offer one is keeping something back.

And that is the final point, and the reason this essay is written the way it is. The deepest form of power is not the power to make you obey. It is the power to keep you from understanding the arrangement you are in—to make the lever invisible, and your compliance feel like character.

The antidote is not suspicion. It is literacy. Not cynicism—most people holding levers are not villains, and most arrangements are not traps. But you should know the shape of the thing, because the shape is always the same, whether it is a boss or a state or a screen or a god.

So: know what you want. Know what you would give for it. Know what you would do instead. And know what the arrangement is asking of you.

That is not cynicism. It is the ordinary care you would take with anything valuable—including your own time.

A coda

One last thing, and it is the thing this essay cannot give you.

Reading all of this does not make you immune. A person can know the mechanism, name it, teach it, and still be moved by someone who has read the same pages and decided to use them. A highly skilled and competent lever-holder—the kind people call a grandmaster—does not need you to be ignorant. He needs you to be human. He will agree with you about the lever, praise your clarity, and stand beside you while you inspect everyone else's terms. You will feel lucid and free. You will not notice that you have stopped inspecting his.

No essay can protect you from that. The five questions are useful against the ordinary lever-holder. They are not a shield against the extraordinary one, because the extraordinary one does not attack your understanding. He recruits it.

Against that, the only thing that has ever worked is a person—someone who knows you well enough to notice when you have stopped asking, and who does not need you to be the one who sees clearly. Not a theory. A witness.

But the same is true on the other side, and the essay would be dishonest if it only warned the agent. The principal is not immune either. Reading all of this does not make a lever-holder wise; it makes them better at holding the lever. A principal who has read these pages can now see every instrument at once—the standard, the discovery apparatus, the credibility investment, the formation of desire—and the temptation is to use them all. The temptation is not to become a grandmaster. It is to become a flawless one, and to mistake the absence of obvious extraction for the presence of justice.

The principal's coda has its own five questions, and they are not the same as the agent's.

Is this arrangement one you would defend to the person under it, in plain language, with the terms on the table? Not "would they accept it"—they might, under conditions you have arranged. Would you defend it, aloud, to them?

Could the person under this lever leave without ruin, and would they still stay if they could? If they would not stay, ask what you are relying on. It may be love. It may be lock-in. The two look different from the inside of the principal's position, and they look identical from the outside.

Are you shaping their desires, and if so, are you willing to say so—to them, and to yourself? Every principal shapes. The question is not whether, but whether you are doing it in the light or in the dark, and whether you would still do it if they knew.

Is there a witness on your side too? The agent needs someone who will tell them when they have stopped asking. The principal needs someone who will tell them when they have started taking. The two are different people, and a principal without the second is already on the way to being the kind of lever-holder this essay began by describing.

And the hardest one, which is the principal's version of the agent's fifth question: **is the good you are offering yours, or is it the good that happens to serve you?** Most principals never ask this, because the answer is uncomfortable. The ones who ask it, and who are willing to be changed by the answer, are the ones who can hold a lever without becoming captured by it.

That is the principal's coda, and it is not a softer one. It is harder, because the principal has more to lose and more room to rationalize. The agent's danger is being formed. The principal's danger is being flattered—by the agents who accept, by the institutions that confirm, by the small daily evidence that the arrangement is working. The principal who is never contradicted is a principal who is already being governed by the people around them, and does not know it.

The lever is defeated by alternatives, and the alternatives are built by people whose interests

might not align wholly with yours. That is the last and plainest thing this essay has to say, and it is true on both sides of the lever. The rest is up to who is standing next to you—and how honestly the two of you can talk about what each of you wants.

A note on the text: the intellectual machinery behind this essay—the formal model of the lever, the contests over discovery and formation, the network theory of corruption and capture, and the analyses of work and governance as levers—is developed in a longer academic paper. This essay is the plain-language version. It is meant to be read on its own, and it is meant to be shared.